10.11.6 Cultivation of Medicinal and Aromatic Plants

Globalization has brought opportunities and challenges in all business sectors. Government of India has identified medicinal and aromatic plants as one of the sectors that can make India a global leader in the 21st century owing to the treasure of about **8,000** medicinal and **2,500** aromatic plants that can provide large number of consumer products with national and international demand. Medicinal plants synthesize a number of secondary metabolites with pharmacological properties through secondary metabolism. The chemicals isolated from medicinal plants are used in traditional and biomedicine systems to treat diseases of both humans and animals. But most of the medicinal and aromatic plants are still wild collecting.

Central Institute of Medicinal and Aromatic Plants (CIMAP) has developed a number of high yielding varieties and processing technologies to promote cultivation of medicinal and aromatic plants. Profitable cultivation of medicinal plants can be practiced by the entrepreneurs along with traditional agriculture horticulture crops. They can be profitably intercropped in plantations. Cultivation of medicinal/aromatic plants offers following advantages:

- Generate employment through development of ancillary industries.
- Foreign exchange earnings through exports.
- Crops are not damaged by domestic animals or by birds.
- Technologies are farmer and eco-friendly.

I. Cultivation of Medicinal Plant - *Gloriosa superba*

Economically useful part – Seed, Rhizome.

Major constituents - Colchicine (0.5-0.7%) and Colchicoside

Uses - Cures gout, anti-inflammatory, anticancer.

National Medicinal Plants Board (NMPB)

Government of India has set up National Medicinal Plants Board (NMPB) on 24th November 2000. Currently this board is working under AYUSH Government of India. Developing an apt mechanism for coordination of various ministries and implementation of policies for overall growth of medicinal plant sector both at central / state and international level is the primary mandate of NMPB. It focusses on in-situ and ex-situ conservation and enhancing local medicinal plants and aromatic species of medicinal significance to meet the growing demand.



Figure 10.26: *Gloriosa superba*

Soil and Climate: Red loamy soils are well suited for cultivation. Glory lily is cultivated in Tamil Nadu mainly in the parts of Tirupur, Dindigul, Karur and Salem districts covering an area of 2000 hectare.

Planting: Planting is distributed from June – July. **P**lough the field 2 -3 times and add 10 tons of Farmyard Manure during last ploughing. Trenches of 30 cm depth are formed and tubers are planted at 30 – 45 cm spacing. The vines are trained over support.

Irrigation: Irrigation should be given immediately after planting. Subsequent irrigation is given at 5 days intervals of time.

Harvest: Pods are harvested at 160 – 180 days.

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